

The Strongest Woman in the Room

Today is the day of the competition. Andrea wakes up early. Her hands are cold. Her heart beats fast.

At the gym, many people are there. They all look strong. Andrea feels small.

She closes her eyes. She thinks of her first day — the big machines, the strange words, the kind trainer. She thinks of Lucia, her friend. She thinks of all the mornings she came back.

"I can do this," she says.

It is her turn. She walks to the bar. She takes a breath. She lifts.

The weight goes up. The people clap. The trainer smiles.

Andrea wins her group.

She sits down. Her arms hurt. But she is happy. Very happy.

Then she sees a woman near the door. The woman looks lost. She looks scared.

Andrea knows that feeling.

She stands up. She walks to the woman. She smiles.

"Hello," she says. "My name is Andrea. Come. I will show you."